is an ancient, powerful and well-established State, which the Bolsheviks are not, and because she is wealthy. We can easily get rid of our connection with the Bolsheviks and restrain the Indian seditionists if it is made worth our while. But we want to know how much Britain will give.[92]

As Montagu had predicted, Afghanistan was, in effect, trying to precipitate a bidding war between Soviet Russia and India. For his part, Dobbs tried to emphasise the danger to Afghanistan if it chose to trust in the Bolshevik regime. For, if the Afghan government allowed Bolshevik propagandists to travel freely through its territory into India, it was inevitable that some of that propaganda would be spread through Afghanistan itself.[93] By September, the Indian government's handling of the situation appeared to be having some success; the Foreign and Political Department reported that the Afghan government was opening its eyes 'to the dangers which they would invite by permitting Bolshevist agitators to enter Afghanistan ostensibly to promote agitation in India and by having too intimate relations with the Soviet Government'.[94]

Together with trying to prevent Afghanistan from becoming a channel for Bolshevik propagandists, the Indian government was also sensible enough to be taking precautions within India itself. In October 1919, it proposed appointing a special officer attached to the Foreign and Political Department 'whose duty would be the reception, collation, digestion and dissemination of information regarding activities of Bolshevists, indeed specially to study the whole problem', as well as increasing intelligence staff in the provinces and enacting special legislation that would prohibit anyone from possessing the rouble note.[95] This last measure, passed on 6 December 1919, proved so effective (depriving, as it did, Bolshevik agitators of the means of directly financing propaganda within India) that the temporary ordinance was prolonged in June 1920.[96] To a large extent, these measures were pre-emptive, as the secretary to the Indian government explained to the local administrations: 'Though actual proof of Bolshevik activity in India itself is small, the Government of India think that a serious situation may develop unless systematic protective measures are adopted.' The government's defensive policy was thus to include not only the officer